HANTHAWADDY PEGU (1287–1540)

Following the fall of Bagan in 1287, the Mon withdrew to the south and reestablished their old kingdom in Lower Burma. Under Wareru, the son-in-law of Rāma Gāmhèn of Sukhothai, the Mon captured the cities of Martaban and Pegu, thus establishing Mon control over Lower Burma. As Pegu began to dominate Lower Burma, the capital was shifted to Pegu in 1369. Pegu would prosper under the Wareru dynasty and remain the capital of the Mon kingdom of Ramanadesa from 1369 to 1539, when it fell to the Burman.

Pegu's rise to prominence is associated with the reign of Rajadhirit (r. ca. 1385–1423) as he launched a series of military campaigns against the Ava kings Mingyiswasawke (r. ca. 1368–1401) and his son, Minkhaung (r. ca. 1401–1422). Rajadhirit's death in 1423 set off a succession struggle as a number of royal claimants emerged. Rajadhirit was finally succeeded by his daughter, Queen Shinsawbu (r. ca. 1453–1492) in 1453. During the interregnum Pegu began to prosper as a commercial and trading center, exporting rice to both India and Malaysia. Pegu also took advantage of the increase in maritime trade in the Indian Ocean to extend its control of the port cities of Bassein-Myaungma, Dala-Syriam, and Sandoway. It was during this period of commercial expansion that Europeans first came to Burma. In 1435, a Venetian trader named Nicolo di Conti became the first European to visit Burma. He stayed in Pegu for four months and described what he saw in his diaries. Other European merchants would follow in di Conti's footsteps. In 1496, during the reign of Binnya Ran (r. ca. 1492–1526), a Russian merchant named Nikitin and a Genoese merchant, Hieronymo Santo Stefano, also visited Pegu.

Queen Shinsawbu was succeeded by the former Buddhist monk Dhammazedi (r. ca. 1472–1492). The reign of Dhammazedi is considered to be Pegu's golden age, as he oversaw the purification of Buddhism in Pegu. Upon his ascension to the throne Dhammazedi found confusion and doctrinal differences over Buddhist practices. Buddhism was, in his view as a former Buddhist monk, deteriorating. The sangha was divided into sects over the interpretation of monastic rules. Monasteries and monks were conducting ecclesiastical acts separately. Dhammazedi was convinced the only way sasana could be unified and purified was the restoration of higher